Brain-age research summary: cohorts, experiments, the best model and what mattered

📄 **PDF version of this notebook** (figures, tables and formulas, no code; regenerate with `scripts/notebook_to_pdf.py notebooks/brain_age_research_summary.ipynb`).

One notebook for the whole EEG brain-age study on TUH (2026-10-05 → 10-16), in three phases:

- **Phase 1, TUAB only.** About 50 fine-tunes of LaBraM-base on the TUH Abnormal corpus (TUAB), aimed at memorization: schedule, regularizers, mixup/EMA, loss shape, codebook regularization, heads, training from scratch (`docs/age_overfitting_experiments.md`).
- **Phase 2, full TUH.** The same recipe on cohorts drawn from the whole TUH EEG corpus (TUEG, about 60k recordings), plus data, input and head changes (`docs/data/tuh_cohort_eval_v1.csv`).
- **Phase 3, cross-validation.** 5-fold patient-grouped CV of the three strongest phase-2 configurations (`notebooks/tuh_cv_summary.ipynb`, `docs/data/cv5_eval_v2.csv`).

It answers four questions:

1. Which datasets and cohorts were used, and how they differ (Section 1).
2. Which experiments ran and which came out near the best (Section 2).
3. What exactly the best experiment does, step by step (Section 3).
4. What changed relative to LaBraM as published (Section 4), and which of those changes measurably moved the error (Section 5).

Contents. 0 Metrics and evaluation sets · 1 Data · 2 Experiments · 3 The best experiment · 4 Changes versus the LaBraM recipe · 5 Which changes mattered · 6 Conclusions.

Inputs.

- In git: the registry, the two CSVs, `docs/data/line_removal_ab.json`, the configs, `docs/data/brain_age_clearml_runs.csv` (each run's ClearML experiment) and `scripts/submit_tuh_cohorts.sh`. Every phase-2 run's configuration is rebuilt from `labram/eval/research_summary.py::PHASE2` with the same config loader the trainer uses. `tests/test_research_summary.py` checks that catalog against the submit script.
- Optional, on the TUH data volume (`LABRAM_TUH_ROOT`, default `/data/datasets/EEG-public/TUH_EEG`):
  - the cohort manifests behind Section 1's counts;
  - the per-recording CV predictions behind the bootstraps (`LABRAM_CV_EVAL`).

They stay out of git under the TUH data-use agreement. Without them those cells print a note and skip, and the outputs show only aggregate counts.

0. Metrics and evaluation sets

Every error is computed **per recording**. A recording's predicted age is the mean of its window predictions (Eq. (3.7)), in years. For a set S of recordings with true age y_i and predicted age $\hat{y}_i$:

$$\mathrm{MAE}(S) = \frac{1}{|S|} \sum_{i \in S} |\hat{y}_i - y_i| \tag{0.1}$$

$$R^2(S) = 1 - \frac{\sum_{i \in S} (\hat{y}_i - y_i)^2}{\sum_{i \in S} (y_i - \bar{y}_S)^2} \tag{0.2}$$

$$\mathrm{bias}(S) = \frac{1}{|S|} \sum_{i \in S} (\hat{y}_i - y_i) \tag{0.3}$$

where $\bar{y}_S$ is the mean true age of S (`labram/eval/cv_compare.py::metrics`). The effect of a change from a baseline run b to a variant run v is

$$\Delta\mathrm{MAE} = \mathrm{MAE}_v(S) - \mathrm{MAE}_b(S), \tag{0.4}$$

so **negative is better**. Section 5 defines when a Δ is larger than run-to-run noise.

Evaluation sets.

- **TUAB test:** TUAB's official evaluation set, 274 recordings of 251 patients (149 normal, 125 abnormal). It is the same 274 recordings in every phase (checked in Section 1) and no training split contains any of its patients, so it is the one yardstick every run shares.
- **Val:** each run's own validation split. It differs between cohorts, so it compares runs only within a cohort.
- **CV test / TUEG out-of-fold:** each recording of the CV pool scored by the one fold model that never saw its patient.

Caveat. Phases 1 and 2 compared many configurations on the TUAB test set, which makes their best single-split numbers optimistically selected. The CV numbers (Phase 3) and the TUEG out-of-fold error were not used to choose anything.

```
registry: 45 phase-1 runs; cohort CSV: 19 phase-2 runs; CV CSV: 3 experiments x 5 folds
TUH data volume: found; per-recording CV predictions: found
```

1. Data: every dataset and cohort

All data comes from the TUH EEG corpus. TUAB (TUH Abnormal, about 3k recordings with a normal/abnormal label) is a subset of TUEG (the full TUH EEG corpus, about 60k recordings). The age label is parsed from each EDF header (`labram/data/tuh_metadata.py`). Every dataset uses the same signal format:

- 23 referential channels at 200 Hz in µV, 0.1–75 Hz band-pass;
- 10 s windows;
- the first and last 60 s of each recording dropped;
- evaluation on the first 5 minutes after the trim (`labram/data/window_selection.py`).

The datasets differ in which recordings they contain, how mains interference is removed, and how patients are split.

Lineage.

- `TUAB v3.0.0` (phase 1) → `TUAB v3.0.1 interp` (phase-2 control): same recordings and split, mains removed by 50 + 60 Hz spectrum interpolation instead of a 50 Hz notch.
- `normal_tueg_v1` , `normal_both_v1` : normal recordings only (TUEG alone; TUAB + TUEG).
- `all_both_v1` → `v2` → `v3` : every recording (normal, abnormal, unlabelled), with TUAB patients kept in their TUAB split.
  - `v2` gives TUEG one patient split shared by every cohort, so validation is comparable across cohorts.
  - `v3` adds the TUEG recordings that lack only the T1/T2 electrodes.
- `v3_compact` / `v3_cvcompact` : byte-for-byte subsets of `v3` that store only the windows a run reads (`dataset_maker/make_compact_cohort.py`). `cvcompact` keeps both training and evaluation windows of every recording, so any CV fold can use any recording.

All cohorts are built by `dataset_maker/make_cohort_dataset.py` , which drops every TUEG recording of a TUAB-test patient and asserts that no patient is in two splits.

Table 1.1. Datasets and cohorts

One row per dataset.

column	meaning
`phase`	the phase that used the dataset
`contents`	which recordings it holds
`line removal`	how mains interference is removed (from the dataset's `manifest.json`)
`rules`	inclusion rules: `age` range in years; `≥ min` minimum recording length in minutes; `≤ k/patient` at most *k* train/val recordings per patient; `T1/T2 may be missing`
`TUEG split`	how TUEG patients are split; TUAB patients always keep their TUAB split
`used by`	the runs of Tables 2.2–2.4 trained on it

dataset	phase	contents	line removal	rules	TUEG split	used by
TUAB v3.0.0	1	TUAB, all recordings (normal + abnormal)	notch:50	age 1–89 (TUAB)	TUAB: seeded 20 % val, official test	phase-1 runs (Table 2.2)
TUAB v3.0.1 interp	2	TUAB, all recordings	interp:50,60	age 1–89 (TUAB)	TUAB: seeded 20 % val, official test	Control
normal_tueg_v1	2	TUEG normal, patients outside TUAB; no test split	interp:50,60	age 18–89, ≥ 5 min, ≤ 10/patient	seeded 10 % val	Exp2
normal_both_v1	2	TUAB normal + TUEG normal	interp:50,60	age 18–89, ≥ 5 min, ≤ 10/patient	seeded 10 % val	Exp1, Exp1b, Exp1t, Exp1f
all_both_v1	2	TUAB + TUEG, every recording (normal / abnormal / no label)	interp:50,60	age 18–89, ≥ 5 min, ≤ 10/patient	seeded 10 % val	Exp3, Exp3b, Exp3q, Exp3c
all_both_v2	2	as v1, TUEG patients on the shared split	interp:50,60	age 18–89, ≥ 5 min, ≤ 10/patient	shared patient split v2	Exp3v2, Exp3cond, Exp3clscond
all_both_v3	2	v2 + TUEG recordings missing only T1/T2	interp:50,60	age 18–89, ≥ 5 min, ≤ 10/patient, T1/T2 may be missing	shared patient split v2	Exp4drop, Exp4base, Exp4ctrl, Exp4aug, Exp4aug15
all_both_v3_compact	2	v3, only the windows Exp4base reads	interp:50,60	age 18–89, ≥ 5 min, ≤ 10/patient, T1/T2 may be missing	shared patient split v2	Exp4basec
all_both_v3_cvcompact	3	v3, training + evaluation windows of every recording (CV pool = train + val)	interp:50,60	age 18–89, ≥ 5 min, ≤ 10/patient, T1/T2 may be missing	shared patient split v2	cvbase, cvctrl, cvaug

Table 1.2. Size and composition per split

For each dataset and split:

- `recordings` and `patients`;
- `from TUAB`: recordings that are also in TUAB;
- `normal` / `abnormal` / `no label`: the recording's report status (TUEG recordings without a normal/abnormal report have no label);
- `age mean` and `age sd`: the true age's mean and sample standard deviation (years).

Computed from each dataset's `cohort.parquet` / `manifest.json`, or from `age_split.json` + `age_metadata.json` for the TUAB-only datasets (`labram/eval/research_summary.py::cohort_summary`, `tuab_split_summary`).

dataset	split	recordings	patients	from TUAB	normal	abnormal	no label	age mean	age sd
TUAB v3.0.0	**train**	2145	1650	2145	1075	1070	0	49.2	17.7
	val	556	412	556	291	265	0	48.4	15.9
	test	274	251	274	149	125	0	50.4	18.1
TUAB v3.0.1 interp	**train**	2145	1650	2145	1075	1070	0	49.2	17.7
	val	556	412	556	291	265	0	48.4	15.9
	test	274	251	274	149	125	0	50.4	18.1
normal_tueg_v1	**train**	3763	2150	0	3763	0	0	48.6	17.6
	val	395	239	0	395	0	0	49.9	16.9
normal_both_v1	**train**	5450	2995	775	5450	0	0	47.2	17.2
	val	843	458	196	843	0	0	46.6	15.7
	test	274	251	274	149	125	0	50.4	18.1
all_both_v1	**train**	20368	9069	1879	8204	10610	1554	52.0	17.5
	val	2905	1235	478	1254	1310	341	51.3	16.3
	test	274	251	274	149	125	0	50.4	18.1
all_both_v2	**train**	20470	9087	1879	8277	10617	1576	51.9	17.5
	val	2803	1217	478	1181	1303	319	51.6	16.5
	test	274	251	274	149	125	0	50.4	18.1
all_both_v3	**train**	25613	12017	1868	10067	13714	1832	52.4	17.5
	val	3422	1533	482	1388	1676	358	52.1	16.8
	test	274	251	274	149	125	0	50.4	18.1
all_both_v3_compact	**train**	25613	12017	1868	10067	13714	1832	52.4	17.5
	val	3422	1533	482	1388	1676	358	52.1	16.8
	test	274	251	274	149	125	0	50.4	18.1
all_both_v3_cvcompact	**train**	25613	12017	1868	10067	13714	1832	52.4	17.5
	val	3422	1533	482	1388	1676	358	52.1	16.8
	test	274	251	274	149	125	0	50.4	18.1

```
TUAB test: 274 recordings; identical in every dataset with a test split: True
{'TUAB v3.0.0': True, 'TUAB v3.0.1 interp': True, 'normal_both_v1': True, 'all_both_v
1': True, 'all_both_v2': True, 'all_both_v3': True, 'all_both_v3_compact': True, 'all_b
oth_v3_cvcompact': True}
```

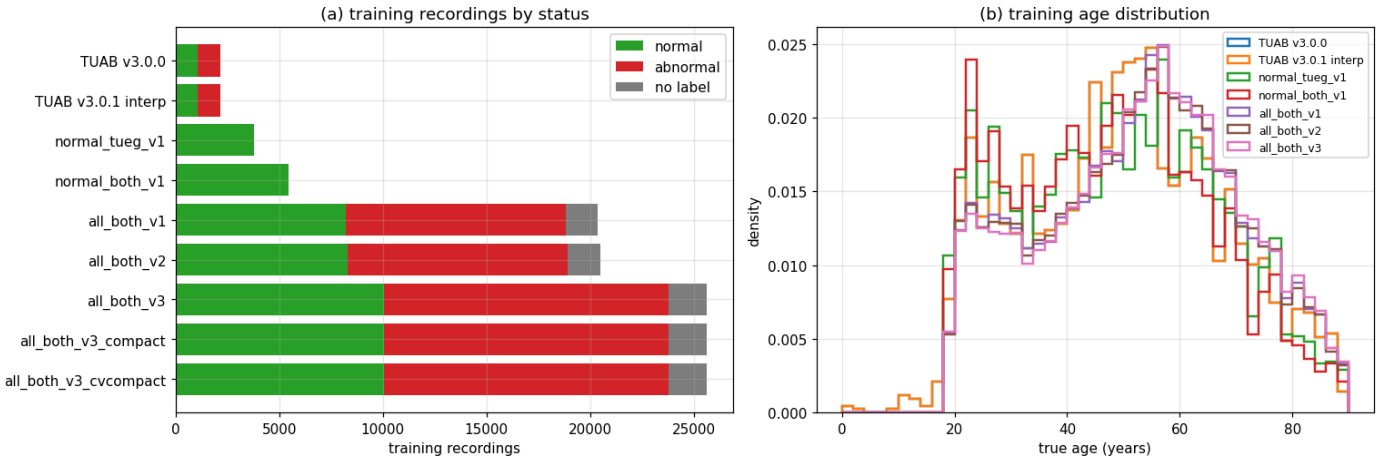
Reading Table 1.2.

- **Scale:** training grows from 2,145 TUAB recordings (phase 1) to 25,613 recordings of about 12k patients (`all_both_v3`).
- **Composition:** in the `all_both` cohorts about half the training recordings are abnormal and about 7 % have no label.
- **Normal-only cohorts:** `normal_*` hold only normal recordings, but their test split is still the full TUAB test set, abnormal recordings included.
- **Test set:** the 274 TUAB test recordings are identical across datasets (the check above), so every TUAB test number in Sections 2–5 is on the same recordings.

Figure 1.1. Composition and age of the training sets

- (a) Training recordings per dataset, stacked by status (normal / abnormal / no label).
- (b) Distribution of true age (years) in each dataset's training split, as a density (step histogram, 2-year bins). Datasets with identical training sets (the `v3` copies) are drawn once.

Data volume required.



2. Experiments

Phase 1 (TUAB only) starts from scenario **D**, the default `finetune_tuab_age.json` (Table 2.1 lists how it differs from LaBraM's own fine-tuning recipe):

- LaBraM-base with a common average reference (Eq. (3.1));
- Huber loss on the z-scored age;
- lr 10^{-4}, 15 epochs.

E2 shortens it to 4 epochs / 1 warmup epoch, and **M1** = E2 + mixup $\alpha = 0.4$. Every **phase-2** run is M1 plus the change named in its row (`labram/eval/research_summary.py::M1`). **Phase 3** cross-validates the three strongest phase-2 configurations.

ClearML. Tables 2.2–2.5 link every run to its ClearML experiment; the link text is the experiment's name in ClearML (`docs/data/brain_age_clearml_runs.csv` , written from the ClearML server by `labram/eval/research_summary.py::fetch_clearml_runs`). A CV run links to the ClearML project that holds its five fold experiments.

Table 2.1. Base configuration D versus the LaBraM fine-tuning recipe

Every configuration field on which LaBraM's TUAB fine-tuning recipe as published and the base configuration D differ:

- `LaBraM paper` : `labram/configs/defaults/finetune_tuab_paper.json` , the normal/abnormal fine-tune of LaBraM-base from the paper and the README;
- `D` : `labram/configs/defaults/finetune_tuab_age.json` as is, without overrides.

Both are rebuilt by `rs.resolve_config` and compared by `labram/eval/research_summary.py::config_diff` . Excluded:

- bookkeeping fields (paths, logging, infrastructure);
- classification-only fields a regression run never reads (`INERT_FOR_REGRESSION` , e.g. label smoothing);
- fields of a section that is off in both.

`group` is the part of the pipeline and `meaning` what the change does. Every other field is the paper's: LaBraM-base from `labram-base.pth` , batch 64, AdamW with weight decay 0.05, layer decay 0.65, drop path 0.1, mean pooling, cosine schedule. Changes that live in the data rather than the configuration (mains-interference removal, splits, labels) are in Table 4.2; how the best configuration differs from the paper's recipe is Table 4.1.

group	field	LaBraM paper	D	meaning
task	data.dataset	TUAB	TUAB_AGE	age regression on TUAB (age from the EDF header) instead of normal/abnormal
	model.task	classification	regression	scalar regression head, Huber loss on the z-scored age (Eqs. (3.2), (3.4))
data	data.data_format	pickle	npy	storage only: one float32 npy per recording, windows bit-identical to the pickles
input	labram_plus.enabled	False	True	LaBraM++ input block on: common average reference (Eq. (3.1))
	labram_plus.z_score_patches	True	False	LaBraM++ block with CAR only, no per-patch z-scoring
windows	data.eval_minutes	0	5	score each recording on its first 5 minutes after the trim
	data.trim_end_sec	0	60	drop the last 60 s of every recording
	data.trim_start_sec	0	60	drop the first 60 s of every recording
scoring	evaluation.agg_windows	none	mean	one prediction per recording = mean of its windows (Eq. (3.7))
optimizer	optimizer.lr	0.0005	0.0001	peak lr 1e-4 instead of 5e-4
schedule	optimizer.warmup_epochs	5	2	2 warmup epochs instead of 5
	trainer.epochs	50	15	15 epochs instead of 50

Table 2.2. Phase 1: TUAB-only runs

The experiment registry's master table (`docs/age_overfitting_experiments.md` , Table 12.1).

- `ClearML` : the run's ClearML experiment, linked by its name.
- `change` : relative to D unless it names another run.
- `val` , `test` : MAE (Eq. (0.1)) on the TUAB validation split (556 recordings) and on TUAB test (274), at the epoch with the lowest validation MAE.
- `test normal` / `test abnormal` : MAE on the two test cohorts.
- `β` : slope of the error against true age (regression to the mean; registry Eq. (1.4)).
- `best epoch` / `epochs` : the selected epoch and the schedule length.

The pre-study baseline (LaBraM fine-tuned with the original recipe adapted to regression) scored val 8.31 / test 9.04 (`docs/age_training_scenario_D.md` , Section 1).

run	ClearML	family	change	val	test	test normal	test abnormal	β	best epoch	epochs
A	age_A_ep15_lr1e-4_fullrec_20261005_043322_643	Evaluation protocol	B with whole-recording val/test	8.29	9.03	–	–	-0.46	2.00	12.00
B	age_B_eval5min_20261005_064356_435	Evaluation protocol	CAR off, 15 ep, lr 1e-4, 5-min eval (pre-D baseline)	8.40	8.91	–	–	-0.43	2.00	6.00
D	age_D_eval5min_car_20261005_013250_973	Baseline	B + CAR (finetune_tuab_age.json)	7.77	8.30	–	–	-0.40	1.00	15.00
D-npy	age_D_eval5min_car_npy_file_20261006_185443_758	Baseline (repro)	D on the npy format	7.77	8.30	–	–	-0.40	1.00	15.00
D-cohorts	age_D_npy_cohorts_20261007_064710_242	Baseline (repro)	D, local, cohort metrics	7.77	8.31	6.57	10.38	-0.40	1.00	15.00
E2	age_E2_npy_ep4_warm1_20261007_070635_244	Schedule	D, 4 ep / 1 warmup	7.68	8.25	–	–	-0.37	3.00	4.00
L1	age_L1_ep12_mixup_ema_20261009_095540_331	Schedule	M12 on 12 ep / 2 warmup	7.51	8.47	6.65	10.63	-0.42	3.00	12.00
C2	age_C2_eval5min_regularized_20261005_012652_087	Classic regularizers	B + ld 0.5, dp 0.2, drop 0.1, wd 0.1, clip 1	12.47	13.52	–	–	-0.81	14.00	15.00
DX3	age_DX3_npy_regularized_20261007_070603_726	Classic regularizers	D + C2 bundle	12.83	14.90	–	–	-1.00	0.00	15.00
F1	age_F1_short_ld05_20261008_215552_344	Classic regularizers	E2 + layer decay 0.5	7.74	8.36	6.42	10.68	-0.36	3.00	4.00
F2	age_F2_short_drop01_20261008_230105_724	Classic regularizers	E2 + dropout 0.1	13.25	15.17	13.37	17.32	-0.97	0.00	4.00
F3	age_F3_short_dp02_20261008_232500_075	Classic regularizers	E2 + drop path 0.2	7.70	8.41	6.31	10.91	-0.35	3.00	4.00
F4	age_F4_short_wd01_20261008_232504_307	Classic regularizers	E2 + weight decay 0.1	7.66	8.24	6.49	10.32	-0.37	3.00	4.00
G1	age_G1_short_init1_20261008_230259_560	Head init	E2 + init_scale 1.0	7.76	8.38	6.64	10.45	-0.37	3.00	4.00
H1	age_H1_short_ld075_20261009_003609_895	Layer decay	E2 + layer decay 0.75	7.71	8.67	6.64	11.09	-0.40	1.00	4.00
H2	age_H2_short_ld085_20261009_003617_662	Layer decay	E2 + layer decay 0.85	7.86	8.54	6.74	10.69	-0.42	3.00	4.00
C2-head	age_C2_eval5min_regularized_headonly_20261004_220639_025	Partial fine-tuning	C2, head only	12.77	14.78	–	–	-0.99	5.00	8.00
C2-last	age_C2_eval5min_regularized_lastblock_head_20261005_000707_645	Partial fine-tuning	C2, last block + head	12.50	13.64	–	–	-0.87	6.00	15.00
M3	age_M3_short_lora16_20261008_215551_826	Partial fine-tuning	E2 + LoRA r16, lr 1e-3, ld 1.0	7.68	9.24	7.41	11.42	-0.44	3.00	4.00
M1	age_M1_short_mixup04_20261007_231716_154	Mixup / EMA	E2 + mixup 0.4	7.46	8.45	6.60	10.65	-0.41	3.00	4.00
M1c	age_M1c_short_cmixup04_s5_20261008_001050_123	Mixup / EMA	E2 + C-Mixup 0.4, σ 5 y	7.54	8.23	6.50	10.29	-0.39	3.00	4.00
M2	age_M2_short_ema_20261008_212509_991	Mixup / EMA	E2 + EMA eval (0.9995)	7.58	8.17	6.35	10.35	-0.36	2.00	4.00
M12	age_M12_short_mixup_ema_20261008_204214_769	Mixup / EMA	E2 + mixup 0.4 + EMA eval	7.48	8.45	6.57	10.69	-0.42	3.00	4.00
D2	age_D2_eval5min_l1_20261005_000636_646	Loss	B + L1 loss	8.36	9.32	–	–	-0.46	6.00	15.00
DX2	age_DX2_huber_delta2_20261005_185121_984	Loss	D + Huber δ 2	7.79	8.41	–	–	-0.38	3.00	15.00
M4	age_M4_short_softlabel_20261008_215551_240	Loss	E2 + soft labels σ 2.5 y	7.67	8.59	6.92	10.57	-0.40	3.00	4.00
B1	age_B1_short_balance_sqrtinv_20261009_124653_371	Loss	E2 + age-balanced, sqrt-inverse	7.83	8.48	6.66	10.63	-0.37	2.00	4.00
B2	age_B2_short_balance_inv_20261009_134321_186	Loss	E2 + age-balanced, inverse	7.96	8.57	6.70	10.80	-0.33	1.00	4.00
DX1	age_DX1_amp_freq05_20261006_022243_393	Codebook regularization	D + amplitude reconstruction (½ spectrum)	7.72	8.54	–	–	-0.39	4.00	15.00
DX4	age_DX4_quant_20261005_160655_990	Codebook regularization	D + quantization term, weight 1	7.67	8.44	–	–	-0.39	3.00	15.00
DX4b	age_DX4b_quant_w50_20261005_215817_973	Codebook regularization	D + quantization term, weight 50	7.78	8.66	–	–	-0.37	4.00	15.00
C	age_C_eval5min_win30s_20261004_235942_658	Augmentation / input	B + 30-s windows	8.24	9.35	–	–	-0.42	8.00	15.00
D-clip1	age_D_npy_clip1_20261007_003433_521	Augmentation / input	D + clip 1.0	7.70	8.36	–	–	-0.41	1.00	15.00
E1	age_E1_npy_random_crop_20261007_070629_845	Augmentation / input	D + random crop	7.82	8.56	–	–	-0.40	3.00	15.00
E1c	age_E1c_npy_random_crop_clip1_20261007_070930_530	Augmentation / input	D + random crop + clip 1.0	7.72	8.13	–	–	-0.38	1.00	15.00
E2c	age_E2c_npy_ep4_warm1_clip1_20261007_083022_212	Augmentation / input	E2 + clip 1.0	7.63	8.24	–	–	-0.38	3.00	4.00
D-cls	age_D_npy_cls_head_20261007_003458_637	Head	D, CLS token instead of mean pooling	7.90	8.24	–	–	-0.38	2.00	15.00
D-clsmean	age_D_npy_cls_mean_head_20261007_003450_736	Head	D, [mean patch; CLS] concat	7.80	8.35	–	–	-0.41	1.00	15.00
N2L	age_N2L_ep12_mixup04_clip1_attnhead_20261009_232420_478	Head	D + mixup 0.4 + clip 1 + attention head, 12 ep / 4 warmup	7.63	8.49	6.68	10.64	-0.43	4.00	12.00
MT1	age_MT1_short_mixup04_multitask_20261010_234501_	Head (multi-task)	M1 + age/abnormal multi-task head (seed 0)	7.54	8.38	6.73	10.35	-0.40	3.00	4.00

run	ClearML	family	change	val	test	test normal	test abnor-mal	β	best epoch	epochs
	492									
MT1-seed1	age_MT1_short_mixup04_multitask_seed1_local_20261011_003814_186	Head (multi-task)	MT1, seed 1	7.62	8.54	6.75	10.69	-0.41	3.00	4.00
S1	age_S1_scratch_ep15_20261010_084032_716	From scratch	D, no pretrained weights, ld 1.0	8.79	9.42	7.75	11.42	-0.49	14.00	15.00
S2	age_S2_scratch_d6_mlp_ep15_20261010_092116_377	From scratch	scratch, 6 blocks + MLP head, tuned (seed 0)	8.53	9.30	7.48	11.48	-0.50	12.00	15.00
S2-seed1	age_S2_scratch_d6_mlp_ep15_seed1_local_20261010_142248_698	From scratch	S2, seed 1	8.58	9.44	7.84	11.35	-0.50	14.00	15.00
S3	age_S3_scratch_d6_mlp_aug_ep15_local_20261010_215949_465	From scratch	S2 + label-preserving augmentation + ±800 µV clip	8.93	9.59	7.91	11.59	-0.52	9.00	15.00

Table 2.3. Phase 2: TUH cohort runs

One row per run of `docs/data/tuh_cohort_eval_v1.csv`, from `labram/eval/research_summary.py::PHASE2`:

- `ClearML`: the run's ClearML experiment, linked by its name;
- `cohort` (Table 1.1), `epochs` / `warmup`;
- `cond.`: ✓ if the head also receives the recording's status and pathology vector (Eq. (3.6));
- `parent` and `change`: the run it is compared with in Section 5 and what differs.

Metrics:

- `test all` / `normal` / `abnormal`: TUAB test MAE (Eq. (0.1));
- `R² normal`: Eq. (0.2) on the normal test recordings;
- `TUEG val v2`: MAE on the TUEG part of the shared v2 validation split (2,325 recordings no v2/v3 model trained on), available only for runs scored on it.

run	ClearML	cohort	epochs	cond.	parent	change	test all	nor-mal	ab-nor-mal	R^2 nor-mal	TUEG val v2
Control	tuh_control_tuab_only_M1_interp_20261012_152904_458	tuab_v3.0.1_interp50-60	4 / 1			M1 on TUAB only (the TUAB baseline of phase 2)	8.23	6.42	10.39	0.75	9.29
Exp1	tuh_exp1_normal_both_M1_20261012_133302_883	normal_both_v1	4 / 1		Control	train on normal record-ings only: TUAB normal + TUEG normal	8.03	5.99	10.47	0.78	8.68
Exp2	tuh_exp2_normal_tueg_M1_20261012_134712_671	normal_tueg_v1	4 / 1		Exp1	TUEG normal only (no TUAB in training)	8.00	6.06	10.31	0.78	8.75
Exp1b	tuh_exp1b_normal_both_M1_ep10_20261012_175842_602	normal_both_v1	10 / 3		Exp1	10 epochs / 3 warmup instead of 4 / 1	8.11	6.09	10.52	0.77	8.66
Exp1t	tuh_exp1t_normal_both_M1_ep4_feat-tokens_20261013_091030_953	normal_both_v1	4 / 1		Exp1	classical EEG features as extra transformer tokens	8.80	7.17	10.73	0.70	–
Exp1f	tuh_exp1f_normal_both_M1_ep4_feat-only_20261012_235557_718	normal_both_v1_meta	4 / 1		Exp1	classical EEG features only, MLP head, no EEG encoder	8.13	6.21	10.41	0.77	–
Exp3	tuh_exp3_all_both_M1_20261012_140234_136	all_both_v1	4 / 1		Control	add every TUEG record-ing (normal, abnormal, unlabelled): ~10x train-ing data	7.26	5.57	9.28	0.80	–
Exp3b	tuh_exp3b_all_both_M1_ep10_20261012_205133_238	all_both_v1	10 / 3		Exp3	10 epochs / 3 warmup instead of 4 / 1	7.70	6.17	9.51	0.75	–
Exp3q	tuh_exp3q_all_both_M1_ep4_qc800-0.5_20261013_110534_570	all_both_v1	4 / 1		Exp3	drop windows beyond ±800 µV or with a flat channel	7.34	5.69	9.31	0.79	–
Exp3c	tuh_exp3c_all_both_M1_ep4_clip800_20261013_103559_425	all_both_v1	4 / 1		Exp3	clip the input to ±800 µV inside the model	7.29	5.66	9.22	0.79	–
Exp3v2	tuh_exp3_all_both_v2_M1_ep4_20261013_202310_767	all_both_v2	4 / 1		Exp3	cohort v2: one TUEG pa-tient split shared by ev-ery cohort (data book-keeping only)	7.42	5.46	9.75	0.80	8.00
Exp3cond	tuh_exp3cond_all_both_v2_M1_ep4_cond-status-pathology_20261013_221741_619	all_both_v2	4 / 1	✓	Exp3v2	status + pathology vec-tors concatenated to the pooled feature	7.28	5.39	9.53	0.81	7.90
Exp3clscond	tuh_exp3clscond_all_both_v2_M1_ep4_cls-cond-status-pathology_20261014_094752_639	all_both_v2	4 / 1	✓	Exp3cond	head on the class token instead of the mean patch token	7.25	5.36	9.51	0.81	7.98
Exp4drop	tuh_exp4_dropT1T2_all_both_v3_cond_M1_ep4_20261014_093428_304	all_both_v3	4 / 1	✓	Exp3cond	cohort v3 (+ recordings missing only T1/T2) on 21 channels (T1/T2 dropped everywhere)	7.28	5.26	9.68	0.82	7.76
Exp4base	tuh_exp4base_all_both_v3_M1_ep6_base-fast_20261014_182259_096	all_both_v3	6 / 2		Exp3v2	cohort v3, 23 channels with missing T1/T2 left out per sample; speed settings; 6 / 2 epochs	7.36	5.62	9.44	0.81	7.86
Exp4basec	tuh_exp4basec_all_both_v3_compact_M1_ep6_base-fast-compact_20261015_222728_648	all_both_v3_compact	6 / 2		Exp4base	compact copy of the co-hort, same recorded split (reproduction check)	7.42	5.52	9.68	0.81	7.85
Exp4ctrl	tuh_exp4ctrl_all_both_v3_M1_ep10_cls-cond-ctrl-fast_20261015_034811_426	all_both_v3	10 / 3	✓	Exp4base	class token + condition vectors, 10 / 3 epochs with early stopping	7.30	5.35	9.63	0.81	7.92
Exp4aug	tuh_exp4_augT1T2_v3_clscond_ep6_lam0.1_b128_20261014_180323_818	all_both_v3	6 / 2	✓	Exp4ctrl	T1/T2 batch dropout (p 0.2) + consistency loss (λ 0.1); 6 / 2 epochs	7.29	5.45	9.49	0.82	7.85
Exp4aug15	tuh_exp4_augT1T2_v3_clscond_ep15_lam0.1_b128_20261015_030018_655	all_both_v3	15 / 5	✓	Exp4aug	15 / 5 epochs with early stopping (stopped at 11)	7.17	5.38	9.29	0.81	7.91

Table 2.4. Phase 3: five-fold cross-validation

- **Folds:** the pool is `all_both_v3_cvcompact` train + val (29,035 recordings), split into 5 patient-disjoint folds. For fold k, test = fold k, val = fold $k+1 \bmod 5$, and the other three train. The TUAB test set is in no fold, so each of the 5 fold models also scores it.
- **`ClearML`:** the ClearML project holding the run's five fold experiments, linked by its name.
- **Per-fold columns:** mean ± sample sd over the 5 fold models of the MAE (Eq. (0.1)) on:
  - `CV val`: the fold's own val;
  - `CV test`: the fold's own test;
  - `TUAB test`, with `normal` and `abnormal`.

- **`ens.`:** the TUAB test MAE of the median of the 5 models' predictions (Eq. (3.8)). It needs the per-recording predictions.

Source: `docs/data/cv5_eval_v2.csv`.

run	ClearML	cond.	CV val	CV test	TUAB test	normal	abnor-mal	ens. TUAB test	ens. normal	ens. abnormal
cvbase	tuh_cvbase_all_both_v3_cvcompact_M1_ep5_cv5-base_cv5		8.16 ± 0.11	8.18 ± 0.15	7.49 ± 0.09	5.81 ± 0.10	9.50 ± 0.11	7.44	5.75	9.46
cvctrl	tuh_cvctrl_all_both_v3_cvcompact_M1_ep10_cv5-ctrl_cv5	✓	8.09 ± 0.12	8.08 ± 0.13	7.28 ± 0.14	5.53 ± 0.08	9.37 ± 0.25	7.10	5.31	9.23
cvaug	tuh_cvaug_all_both_v3_cvcompact_M1_ep10_cv5-augT1T2_cv5	✓	8.06 ± 0.13	8.06 ± 0.15	7.33 ± 0.17	5.55 ± 0.17	9.44 ± 0.18	7.23	5.43	9.37

Figure 2.1. TUAB test MAE of every run

Every run's TUAB test MAE (Eq. (0.1), $n = 274$; normal recordings $n = 149$), in the order the runs were made.

- (a) All test recordings.
- (b) Normal test recordings; phase-1 runs without cohort metrics are missing.

Marks:

- Phase 1 (blue), phase 2 (orange), CV (green: the mean ± sd over the 5 fold models, with a star at the median ensemble).
- Hollow markers: runs whose head also receives the status/pathology vector (not EEG-only).
- Collapsed runs (MAE > 11) are drawn at the top edge.
- The dashed line marks the best published TUAB normal result (Gemein et al. 2024, 6.60, normal recordings only), shown in (b).

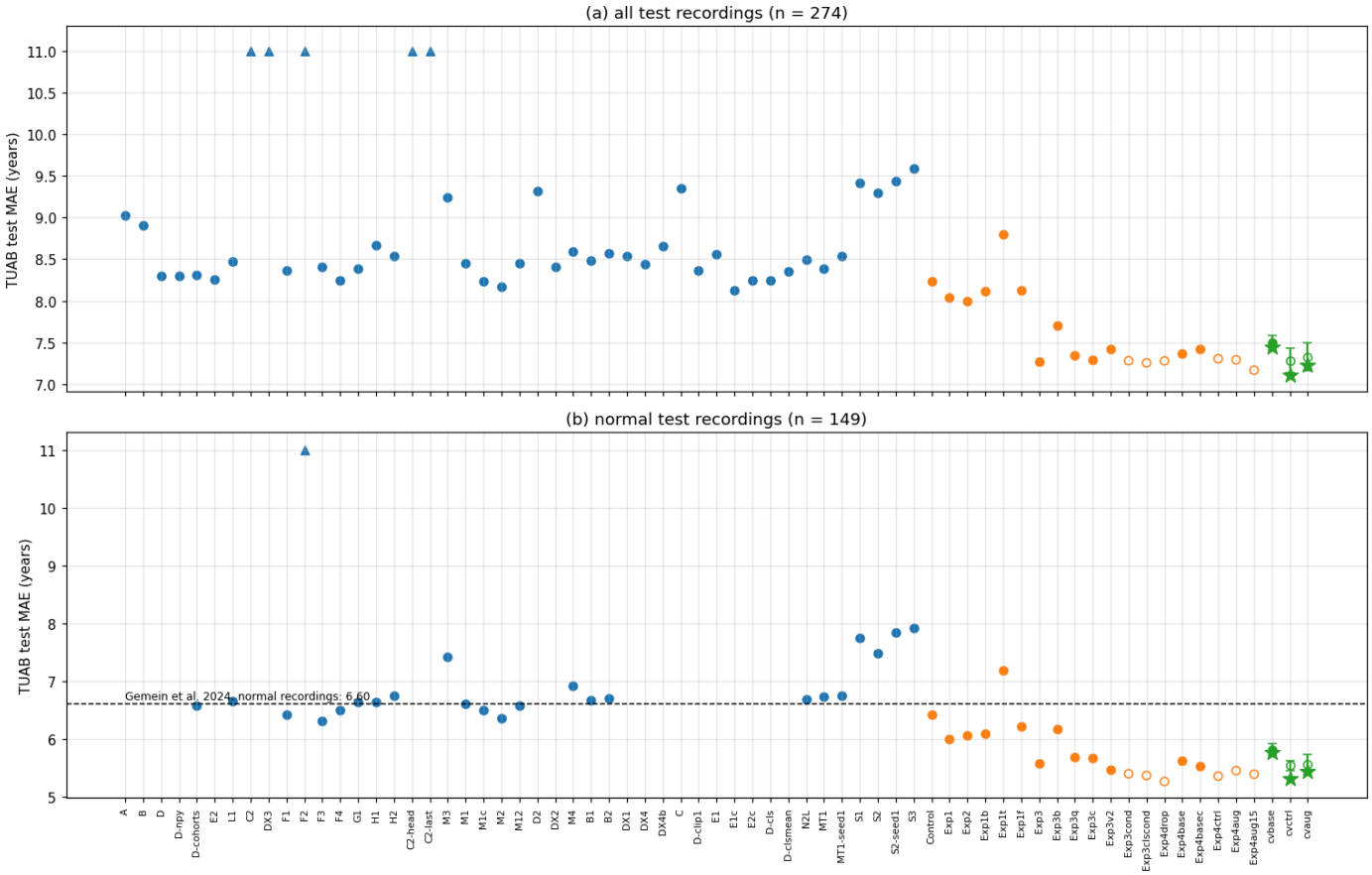


Table 2.5. The runs around the best result

The 12 runs with the lowest TUAB test MAE across all phases (Tables 2.2–2.4):

- `kind`:
  - `single split`: one run;
  - `CV mean`: mean over 5 fold models;
  - `CV ensemble`: median of 5 fold models.
- `cond.`: ✓ if the head is given the status/pathology vector.
- `ClearML`: the run's ClearML experiment (for CV: the project of its folds), linked by its name.
- `test all` / `normal` / `abnormal`: MAE (Eq. (0.1)).

Ranked on `test all`, with the best EEG-only run in each kind marked `◆`.

run	ClearML	kind	phase	cond.	test all	nor-mal	abnor-mal
cvctrl	tuh_cvctrl_all_both_v3_cvcompact_M1_ep10_cv5-ctrl_cv5	CV ensemble	3	✓	7.10	5.31	9.23
Exp4aug15	tuh_exp4_augT1T2_v3_clscond_ep15_lam0.1_b128_20261015_030018_655	single split	2	✓	7.17	5.38	9.29
cvaug	tuh_cvaug_all_both_v3_cvcompact_M1_ep10_cv5-augT1T2_cv5	CV ensemble	3	✓	7.23	5.43	9.37
Exp3clscond	tuh_exp3clscond_all_both_v2_M1_ep4_cls-cond-status-pathology_20261014_094752_639	single split	2	✓	7.25	5.36	9.51
◆ Exp3	tuh_exp3_all_both_M1_20261012_140234_136	single split	2		7.26	5.57	9.28
Exp4drop	tuh_exp4_dropT1T2_all_both_v3_cond_M1_ep4_20261014_093428_304	single split	2	✓	7.28	5.26	9.68
Exp3cond	tuh_exp3cond_all_both_v2_M1_ep4_cond-status-pathology_20261013_221741_619	single split	2	✓	7.28	5.39	9.53
cvctrl	tuh_cvctrl_all_both_v3_cvcompact_M1_ep10_cv5-ctrl_cv5	CV mean	3	✓	7.28	5.53	9.37
Exp3c	tuh_exp3c_all_both_M1_ep4_clip800_20261013_103559_425	single split	2		7.29	5.66	9.22
Exp4aug	tuh_exp4_augT1T2_v3_clscond_ep6_lam0.1_b128_20261014_180323_818	single split	2	✓	7.29	5.45	9.49
Exp4ctrl	tuh_exp4ctrl_all_both_v3_M1_ep10_cls-cond-ctrl-fast_20261015_034811_426	single split	2	✓	7.30	5.35	9.63
cvaug	tuh_cvaug_all_both_v3_cvcompact_M1_ep10_cv5-augT1T2_cv5	CV mean	3	✓	7.33	5.55	9.44

3. The best experiment

Which run is best. Single-split runs were compared on the TUAB test set itself (Section 0). Only the CV runs have an error bar, and their CV test / TUEG out-of-fold errors were never used for selection. So "best" is decided among the CV runs:

- **Best overall:** `cvctrl` (= Exp4ctrl cross-validated). It has the lowest TUAB test MAE, as a single fold model and as a 5-model ensemble (Table 2.4).
  - `cvaug` adds T1/T2 channel-dropout augmentation and ties with it: the differences are within noise in Table 5.2 (C2).
  - The simpler `cvctrl` is therefore the recommended configuration.
- **Best EEG-only:** `cvbase`**.** Its head sees only the EEG. `cvctrl` and `cvaug` also see the recording's status (normal / abnormal / no label) and 13 diagnosis flags from the clinical sheet. A deployed brain-age model would not have these, and published TUAB results do not use them. `cvbase` is therefore the number to compare with the literature (Table 3.3).

Both are LaBraM-base fine-tuned on `all_both_v3` with the M1 recipe. They differ in three settings (Table 3.2): class-token vs mean pooling, the condition vector, and 10 vs 5 epochs.

What the model computes

Input and target. The raw EEG u (µV) of a 10 s window is scaled to $x = u/100$ and cut into 1 s patches $x_{c,a,t}$:

- channel $c = 1..C$, with $C = 23$ minus the missing T1/T2 of that recording;
- patch $a = 1..10$, sample $t = 1..200$.

The common average reference removes what all channels share (`labram/data/preprocess.py::common_average_reference`):

$$\tilde{x}_{c,a,t} = x_{c,a,t} - \frac{1}{C}\sum_{c'=1}^{C} x_{c',a,t} \tag{3.1}$$

The age y (years) is z-scored with the training windows' mean μ and standard deviation σ (`labram/data/tuh_datasets.py::TUABAgeLoader._age_target`):

$$z = \frac{y - \mu}{\sigma} \tag{3.2}$$

Mixup. Each training batch is blended with a permuted copy of itself, using one $\lambda \sim \mathrm{Beta}(\alpha, \alpha)$ per batch with $\alpha = 0.4$ (`labram/train/mixup.py::mixup_batch`). The condition vector c travels with the target, so it is blended too:

$$\bar{x} = \lambda x + (1-\lambda)\, x_\pi, \qquad \bar{z} = \lambda z + (1-\lambda)\, z_\pi, \qquad \bar{c} = \lambda c + (1-\lambda)\, c_\pi \tag{3.3}$$

Loss. Huber loss with $\delta = 1$ on the z-scored residual $r = \hat{z} - \bar{z}$ (`labram/losses/regression.py::build_regression_criterion`):

$$\ell_\delta(r) = \begin{cases} \tfrac{1}{2} r^2 & |r| \le \delta \\ \delta\,(|r| - \tfrac{1}{2}\delta) & \text{otherwise} \end{cases} \tag{3.4}$$

Encoder and head. f_θ is the 12-block LaBraM-base transformer, initialized from the released `labram-base.pth` . Its output is $h \in \mathbb{R}^{200}$:

- the final LayerNorm's class token (`cvctrl` , `cvaug`);
- the mean over patch tokens (`cvbase`).

$$h = f_\theta(\tilde{x}) \tag{3.5}$$

The linear head reads h, concatenated with a 32-d projection of the 17-d condition vector $c \in \{0,1\}^{17}$ (3 one-hot status + 14 multi-hot pathology groups, `conditions_v1.npz`) when conditions are on (`labram/models/neural_transformer.py` , `model.session_features=head`):

$$\hat{z} = w^\top \begin{bmatrix} h \\ W_c\, c \end{bmatrix} + b, \qquad W_c \in \mathbb{R}^{32 \times 17} \tag{3.6}$$

Optimizer and schedule. AdamW with weight decay 0.05. Layer-wise lr decay $\rho = 0.65$ gives block l of $L = 12$ the rate $\mathrm{lr} \cdot \rho^{\,L+1-l}$ (`labram/optim_factory.py::LayerDecayValueAssigner`). The rate warms up linearly, then follows a cosine down to 10^{-6} (`labram/utils/training.py`).

Scoring. A recording's prediction is the de-normalized mean over its evaluation windows W_i (the first 5 minutes after the trim, 30 windows; `evaluation.agg_windows=mean`):

$$\hat{y}_i = \mu + \sigma\, \frac{1}{|W_i|} \sum_{w \in W_i} \hat{z}_w \tag{3.7}$$

The fold ensemble takes the median over the $K = 5$ fold models (`labram/eval/cv_compare.py::ensemble`):

$$\hat{y}_i^{\text{ens}} = \text{median}_{k=1..K}\ \hat{y}_{i,k} \tag{3.8}$$

Table 3.1. The best configuration (`cvctrl`), step by step

One row per stage of the pipeline:

- `setting` : the configuration field;
- `cvctrl` : its value, read from the configuration rebuilt by `rs.resolve_config` (`finetune_tuab_age.json` + the run's overrides, exactly as the trainer builds it);
- `cvbase` : the EEG-only variant's value, where it differs;
- `equation` : where the setting appears above.

stage	what	setting	cvctrl	cvbase	equation
data	**cohort**	data.data_path	all_both_v3_cvcompact		
	5-fold CV, grouped by	cross_validation.split_by	subject		
	CV pool	cross_validation.pool	train_val		
windows	**window length (s)**	data.window_sec	10		
	trim start / end (s)	data.trim_start_sec / data.trim_end_sec	60 / 60		
	train minutes per recording per epoch	data.train_minutes_per_epoch	5		
	eval minutes per recording	data.eval_minutes	5		(3.7)
channels	**channels left out where missing**	channel_drop.channels	["T1", "T2"]		
	T1/T2 dropout probability (augmentation)	channel_drop.prob	0		
input	**common average reference**	labram_plus.common_average_reference	True		(3.1)
	per-patch z-scoring	labram_plus.z_score_patches	False		
encoder	**model**	model.model	labram_base_patch200_200		(3.5)
	initial weights	finetune_checkpoint.finetune	labram-base.pth		
	drop path	model.drop_path	0.1		
	fused attention (speed only)	model.fused_attention	True		
head	**mean pooling (False = class token)**	model.use_mean_pooling	False	True	(3.5)
	condition vector	model.session_features / data.session_features	head / conditions_v1.npz	off /	(3.6)
	condition projection size	model.session_head_dim	32		(3.6)
	output init scale	model.init_scale	0.001		
target	**task**	model.task	regression		(3.2)
loss	**regression loss / δ**	loss.regression_loss / loss.huber_delta	huber / 1		(3.4)
augmentation	**mixup α (on)**	mixup.alpha / mixup.enabled	0.4 / True		(3.3)
optimizer	**AdamW lr / batch**	optimizer.lr / trainer.batch_size	0.0002 / 128		
	weight decay / layer decay	optimizer.weight_decay / optimizer.layer_decay	0.05 / 0.65		
schedule	**epochs / warmup**	trainer.epochs / optimizer.warmup_epochs	10 / 3	5 / 1	
	min lr	optimizer.min_lr	1e-06		
selection	**checkpoint**	–	lowest val MAE (recording level)		
scoring	**window aggregation / case unit**	evaluation.agg_windows / evaluation.agg_case_by	mean / recording		(3.7)

Table 3.2. The three cross-validated configurations

Every configuration field on which `cvbase` , `cvctrl` and `cvaug` disagree (`labram/eval/research_summary.py::config_diff` , bookkeeping fields excluded).

field	cvbase	cvctrl	cvaug
channel_drop.consistency_weight	0	0	0.1
channel_drop.prob	0	0	0.2
data.session_features		conditions_v1.npz	conditions_v1.npz
model.session_features	off	head	head
model.use_mean_pooling	True	False	False
optimizer.warmup_epochs	1	3	3
trainer.epochs	5	10	10

Table 3.3. Results of the best experiment by evaluation set and cohort

`cvctrl` (best overall) and `cvbase` (best EEG-only), mean ± sample sd over the 5 fold models of the MAE (Eq. (0.1)) and the mean R^2 (Eq. (0.2)), per evaluation set and status cohort:

- `CV val`, `CV test`: the fold's own held-out folds, TUAB and TUEG recordings together;
- `TUEG test`: the TUEG recordings of each fold's test fold;
- `TUAB test`: the official test set, $n = 274$.

R^2 is relative to each cohort's own age spread, so it does not compare across cohorts. The last row gives the median ensemble (Eq. (3.8)) on the TUAB test set when the per-recording predictions are available. For reference, the best published TUAB normal-recording result is MAE 6.60, R^2 0.73 (Gemein et al. 2024, trained on TUAB normal recordings only, on its own patient-wise re-split of TUAB).

set	cohort	cvctrl MAE	cvctrl R²	cvbase MAE	cvbase R²
CV val	all	8.09 ± 0.12	0.64	8.16 ± 0.11	0.64
	normal	7.33 ± 0.20	0.68	7.45 ± 0.17	0.68
	abnormal	8.49 ± 0.14	0.60	8.57 ± 0.13	0.59
CV test	all	8.08 ± 0.13	0.64	8.18 ± 0.15	0.63
	normal	7.39 ± 0.18	0.68	7.47 ± 0.14	0.67
	abnormal	8.46 ± 0.11	0.60	8.60 ± 0.15	0.59
TUEG test	all	8.17 ± 0.15	0.63	8.27 ± 0.15	0.62
	normal	7.52 ± 0.19	0.67	7.59 ± 0.16	0.67
	abnormal	8.50 ± 0.10	0.59	8.65 ± 0.13	0.58
TUAB test	all	7.28 ± 0.14	0.71	7.49 ± 0.09	0.70
	normal	5.53 ± 0.08	0.80	5.81 ± 0.10	0.79
	abnormal	9.37 ± 0.25	0.52	9.50 ± 0.11	0.51
TUAB test, ensemble	all	7.10	0.72	7.44	0.70
	normal	5.31	0.82	5.75	0.80
	abnormal	9.23	0.53	9.46	0.52

4. Changes versus the LaBraM recipe

The reference is **LaBraM as published for TUAB**, `labram/configs/defaults/finetune_tuab_paper.json`:

- LaBraM-base fine-tuned for normal/abnormal classification, the recipe of the paper and the README;
- lr $5 \cdot 10^{-4}$, batch 64, 50 epochs with 5 warmup, layer decay 0.65, drop path 0.1;
- no input re-referencing;
- a 50 Hz notch in preprocessing (`dataset_maker/make_TUAB.py`).

Table 4.1 lists every configuration field the best configuration changes. Table 4.2 lists the changes that live in the data or the code rather than the configuration. Section 5 then tests which of them moved the error.

Table 4.1. Configuration changes: LaBraM TUAB recipe → best configuration

Every field on which `finetune_tuab_paper.json` and `cvctrl` (Table 3.1) differ, computed by `labram/eval/research_summary.py::config_diff`. Excluded:

- bookkeeping fields (paths, logging, infrastructure);
- fields a regression run never reads (`INERT_FOR_REGRESSION`);
- fields of a section that is off in both.

Columns:

- `group`: the part of the pipeline;
- `meaning`: what the change does;
- `evidence`: the rows of Table 5.2 that test it, where one does.

group	field	LaBraM recipe	best (cvctrl)	meaning	evidence
augmentation	**mixup.enabled**	False	True	mixup α 0.4 (Eq. (3.3))	P3
channels	**channel_drop.channels**	[]	["T1", "T2"]	T1/T2 are the channels that may be missing	Q14
	channel_drop.consistency_weight	1	0	0: no consistency loss in cvctrl	Q17, C2
	channel_drop.enabled	False	True	per-sample handling of missing T1/T2 (needed for cohort v3)	Q14
	channel_drop.max_drop	1	2	up to both of T1/T2	Q14
	channel_drop.prob	0.2	0	0: no channel-dropout augmentation in cvctrl	Q17, C2
data	**data.data_format**	pickle	npy	storage only: one float32 npy per recording, windows bit-identical to the pickles	
head	**data.session_features**		conditions_v1.npz	the condition vectors' file (conditions_v1.npz)	Q12, C1
	model.session_features	off	head	status + pathology vector concatenated to the feature (Eq. (3.6))	Q12, C1
	model.use_mean_pooling	True	False	head on the class token instead of the mean patch token	P22, Q13, C1
input	**labram_plus.enabled**	False	True	turns on the LaBraM++ input block (Eq. (3.1))	P1
	labram_plus.z_score_patches	True	False	LaBraM++ block with CAR only, no per-patch z-scoring	P1
optimizer	**optimizer.lr**	0.0005	0.0002	2e-4 at batch 128 = 1e-4 at batch 64, linearly scaled	Q14
	trainer.batch_size	64	128	batch 128 (speed; lr scaled with it)	Q14
protocol	**cross_validation.enabled**	False	True	5-fold patient-grouped cross-validation	C3
schedule	**optimizer.warmup_epochs**	5	3	3 warmup epochs	P2, Q6, C1
	trainer.epochs	50	10	10 epochs instead of 50 (best epoch is early)	P2, Q6, C1
scoring	**evaluation.agg_windows**	none	mean	one prediction per recording = mean of its windows (Eq. (3.7))	
speed	**model.fused_attention**	False	True	fused attention kernel, numerically the same model	
task	**data.dataset**	TUAB	TUAB_AGE	age regression on TUH (TUAB_AGE loader) instead of normal/abnormal	
	model.task	classification	regression	scalar regression head (Huber on z-scored age, Eqs. (3.2), (3.4))	
windows	**data.eval_minutes**	0	5	score each recording on its first 5 minutes after the trim	P26
	data.train_minutes_per_epoch	0	5	5 minutes per recording per epoch, redrawn each epoch (speed)	Q14
	data.trim_end_sec	0	60	drop the last 60 s of every recording	
	data.trim_start_sec	0	60	drop the first 60 s of every recording	

Table 4.2. Changes outside the configuration

Changes in the training data, the preprocessing, the split and the code, with the Table 5.2 rows that test them.

change	LaBraM recipe	this study	evidence
training data	TUAB train, 2,145 recordings (≈1.6k patients)	TUAB + TUEG, 25,613 recordings (≈12k patients, `all_both_v3`)	Q1, Q3
mains interference	50 Hz notch (TUH is recorded at 60 Hz, so the line stays in)	50 + 60 Hz spectrum interpolation	L1

change	LaBraM recipe	this study	evi-dence
channels	23 fixed channels	23; TUEG recordings missing only T1/T2 kept, with those channels left out per sample	Q14
validation split	TUAB's train split, which leaks 16 patients between train and val	patient-disjoint, seeded; one TUEG patient split shared by all cohorts; TUAB-test patients removed from TUEG	Q11
label	normal/abnormal	age from the EDF header (18–89 in the TUH cohorts)	–
unit of evaluation	10 s window	recording (Eq. (3.7)), first 5 minutes after the trim	P26
per-patient cap	none	at most 10 train/val recordings per patient	–
reported model	one run	median of 5 fold models (Eq. (3.8))	C3
reproducibility	ClearML silently reseeded every tracked run to 1337	fixed: `distributed.seed` is honoured (commit `7b9a5fe`)	–

5. Which changes mattered

Noise floor. Two runs of the same configuration with different seeds do not give the same MAE. The line-removal A/B study ran each of 3 preprocessing recipes r with 3 seeds s, and each run is read at its best-validation epoch. The pooled within-recipe sample standard deviation of a metric m (`labram/eval/research_summary.py::seed_noise`) is

$$\hat{\sigma}_m^2 = \frac{1}{N - R} \sum_r \sum_s \left(m_{r,s} - \bar{m}_r \right)^2 \tag{5.1}$$

with $N = 9$ runs and $R = 3$ recipes.

Significance rule. Each row of Table 5.2 compares a baseline with a variant that changes one thing (or a named bundle), using whichever evidence exists:

- **One run each** (phases 1 and 2). The difference of two single runs has standard deviation $\sqrt{2}\,\hat{\sigma}$, so a change counts only if (`rs.pair_threshold`)

$$|\Delta \mathrm{MAE}| > \tau = 1.96\,\sqrt{2}\,\hat{\sigma}_{\mathrm{test}}. \tag{5.2}$$

- **Three seeds each** (line removal, L1/L2):

$$|\bar{\Delta}| > 1.96\,\hat{\sigma}_{\mathrm{test}}\,\sqrt{2/3}. \tag{5.3}$$

- **Five paired folds** (CV, C1/C2). Fold k gives Δ_k on the same TUAB test recordings, and the 95 % interval is

$$\bar{\Delta} \pm t_{0.975,\,4}\,\frac{s_\Delta}{\sqrt{5}}, \qquad t_{0.975,\,4} = 2.776, \tag{5.4}$$

  where $\bar{\Delta}$ and s_Δ are the mean and sample sd of the Δ_k. The change counts if the interval excludes 0.

- **Ensemble vs single model** (C3). A paired bootstrap over recordings (2,000 resamples, `cv_compare.py::bootstrap_delta_mae`) of the ensemble's absolute error against the fold models' mean absolute error. The change counts if its 95 % interval excludes 0.

The verdict is `improves` / `hurts` / `n.s.` (`rs.verdict`). It is judged on the TUAB test MAE of all 274 recordings, the one set every run shares; the val and cohort columns are context.

Limits.

- $\hat{\sigma}$ is measured on one configuration family (M1, TUAB) and assumed to hold for the others.
- A single-split row with $|\Delta|$ just under τ is not evidence of no effect, only of no detectable one.
- Several rows change more than one thing at once; they are marked *bundle*.

Table 5.1. Seed-to-seed spread

The 9 age runs of the line-removal A/B study (`docs/data/line_removal_ab.json`), each at its best-validation epoch, then the pooled standard deviation of Eq. (5.1) per metric and the single-pair threshold τ of Eq. (5.2).

- `val_mae` : the TUAB validation split.
- `test_mae` , `test_normal_mae` , `test_abnormal_mae` : TUAB test, overall and per cohort.

variant	seed	epoch	val_mae	test_mae	test_normal_mae	test_abnormal_mae
A_notch50	0	3	7.52	8.43	6.62	10.59
	1	3	7.66	8.40	6.60	10.55
	2	3	7.64	8.24	6.41	10.42
B_notch60	0	2	7.46	8.01	6.39	9.96
	1	3	7.55	8.31	6.55	10.41
	2	3	7.54	8.07	6.38	10.08
C_interp5060	0	2	7.46	8.03	6.39	9.99
	1	3	7.56	8.31	6.54	10.42
	2	3	7.56	8.10	6.39	10.13

```
pooled seed sd (years): val_mae 0.061, test_mae 0.138, test_normal_mae 0.100, test_abno
rmal_mae 0.194
single-pair threshold τ on TUAB test (Eq. 5.2): 0.38 years; 3-vs-3-seed threshold (Eq.
5.3): 0.22 years
```

Table 5.2. Effect of each change

One row per tested change. Columns:

- `id` : the row's id, cited in Tables 4.1, 4.2 and 5.3.
- `phase` : 1 (registry, Table 2.2), 2 (Table 2.3), L (line-removal A/B, Table 5.1), C (CV, Table 2.4).
- `baseline → variant` : the two runs compared; `bundle` marks a change of several things at once.
- `Δ val` : Eq. (0.4) on the validation set the two runs share (phase 1: TUAB val; phase 2: TUEG val v2 where both runs were scored on it).
- `Δ test` , `Δ normal` , `Δ abnormal` : Eq. (0.4) on TUAB test, overall and per cohort.
- `noise` : $\pm\tau$ (Eqs. (5.2), (5.3)) or the 95 % interval (Eq. (5.4) / bootstrap).
- `verdict` : the rule above, on `Δ test` .

id	phase	change	baseline → variant	Δ val	Δ test	Δ normal	Δ abnormal	noise	verdict
P1	1	common average reference on the input	B → D	-0.63	-0.61	–	–	± 0.38	improves
P26	1	score the first 5 min instead of whole recordings	A → B	0.11	-0.12	–	–	± 0.38	n.s.
P2	1	4 epochs / 1 warmup instead of 15 / 2	D → E2	-0.09	-0.05	–	–	± 0.38	n.s.
P3	1	mixup α 0.4	E2 → M1	-0.22	0.20	–	–	± 0.38	n.s.
P4	1	C-Mixup (σ 5 y)	E2 → M1c	-0.14	-0.02	–	–	± 0.38	n.s.
P5	1	EMA weights for evaluation	E2 → M2	-0.10	-0.08	–	–	± 0.38	n.s.
P6	1	layer decay 0.5 (stronger)	E2 → F1	0.06	0.11	–	–	± 0.38	n.s.
P7	1	layer decay 0.75 (weaker)	E2 → H1	0.03	0.42	–	–	± 0.38	hurts
P8	1	dropout 0.1	E2 → F2	5.57	6.92	–	–	± 0.38	hurts
P9	1	drop path 0.2	E2 → F3	0.02	0.16	–	–	± 0.38	n.s.
P10	1	weight decay 0.1	E2 → F4	-0.02	-0.01	–	–	± 0.38	n.s.
P11	1	head init scale 1.0	E2 → G1	0.08	0.13	–	–	± 0.38	n.s.
P12	1	LoRA r16 instead of full fine-tuning (bundle)	E2 → M3	0.00	0.99	–	–	± 0.38	hurts
P13	1	L1 loss instead of Huber	B → D2	-0.04	0.41	–	–	± 0.38	hurts
P14	1	Huber δ 2	D → DX2	0.02	0.11	–	–	± 0.38	n.s.
P15	1	soft labels (σ 2.5 y)	E2 → M4	-0.01	0.34	–	–	± 0.38	n.s.
P16	1	age-balanced loss (sqrt-inverse)	E2 → B1	0.15	0.23	–	–	± 0.38	n.s.
P17	1	codebook amplitude reconstruction	D → DX1	-0.05	0.24	–	–	± 0.38	n.s.
P18	1	codebook quantization term	D → DX4	-0.10	0.14	–	–	± 0.38	n.s.
P19	1	30 s windows instead of 10 s	B → C	-0.16	0.44	–	–	± 0.38	hurts
P20	1	random crop	D → E1	0.05	0.26	–	–	± 0.38	n.s.
P21	1	gradient clipping 1.0	D → D-clip1	-0.07	0.06	–	–	± 0.38	n.s.
P22	1	class token instead of mean pooling	D → D-cls	0.13	-0.06	–	–	± 0.38	n.s.
P23	1	[mean ; class token] concatenated	D → D-clsmean	0.03	0.05	–	–	± 0.38	n.s.
P24	1	multi-task head (age + normal/abnormal)	M1 → MT1	0.08	-0.07	0.13	-0.30	± 0.38	n.s.
P25	1	pretrained LaBraM weights instead of training from scratch	S1 → D	-1.02	-1.12	–	–	± 0.38	improves
L1	L	50 + 60 Hz interpolation instead of 50 Hz notch	A_notch50 → C_interp5060	-0.08	-0.21	-0.10	-0.34	± 0.22	n.s.
L2	L	60 Hz notch instead of 50 Hz notch	A_notch50 → B_notch60	-0.09	-0.23	-0.11	-0.37	± 0.22	improves
Q1	2	add every TUEG recording (~10x data)	Control → Exp3	–	-0.97	-0.85	-1.11	± 0.38	improves
Q2	2	train on normal recordings only (TUAB + TUEG) (bundle)	Control → Exp1	-0.62	-0.20	-0.43	0.08	± 0.38	n.s.
Q3	2	add abnormal + unlabelled recordings to normal-only	Exp1 → Exp3	–	-0.77	-0.41	-1.19	± 0.38	improves
Q4	2	TUEG normal only (no TUAB in training)	Exp1 → Exp2	0.07	-0.03	0.07	-0.16	± 0.38	n.s.
Q5	2	10 / 3 epochs on the normal cohort	Exp1 → Exp1b	-0.02	0.08	0.11	0.05	± 0.38	n.s.
Q6	2	10 / 3 epochs on the all cohort	Exp3 → Exp3b	–	0.43	0.60	0.23	± 0.38	hurts
Q7	2	window rejection (±800 μV, flat channel)	Exp3 → Exp3q	–	0.07	0.12	0.03	± 0.38	n.s.
Q8	2	input clip ±800 μV	Exp3 → Exp3c	–	0.02	0.09	-0.06	± 0.38	n.s.
Q9	2	classical features as transformer tokens	Exp1 → Exp1t	–	0.76	1.19	0.26	± 0.38	hurts
Q10	2	classical features only, no EEG encoder	Exp1 → Exp1f	–	0.10	0.22	-0.06	± 0.38	n.s.
Q11	2	shared TUEG patient split (v2)	Exp3 → Exp3v2	–	0.15	-0.11	0.47	± 0.38	n.s.
Q12	2	status + pathology condition vectors	Exp3v2 → Exp3cond	-0.10	-0.14	-0.07	-0.22	± 0.38	n.s.
Q13	2	class token (with conditions)	Exp3cond → Exp3clscond	0.07	-0.03	-0.03	-0.02	± 0.38	n.s.
Q14	2	cohort v3 + missing-T1/T2 handling + speed settings (bundle)	Exp3v2 → Exp4base	-0.14	-0.05	0.16	-0.31	± 0.38	n.s.
Q15	2	compact copy of the cohort (reproduction)	Exp4base → Exp4basec	-0.01	0.06	-0.10	0.24	± 0.38	n.s.
Q16	2	class token + conditions + 10 ep with early stopping (bundle)	Exp4base → Exp4ctrl	0.05	-0.06	-0.27	0.19	± 0.38	n.s.
Q17	2	T1/T2 dropout + consistency (6 vs 10 epochs) (bundle)	Exp4ctrl → Exp4aug	-0.07	-0.01	0.09	-0.14	± 0.38	n.s.
Q18	2	T1/T2 dropped everywhere (21 channels) + cohort v3 (bundle)	Exp3cond → Exp4drop	-0.15	-0.00	-0.13	0.16	± 0.38	n.s.
Q19	2	15 / 5 epochs with early stopping (aug)	Exp4aug → Exp4aug15	0.06	-0.12	-0.06	-0.20	± 0.38	n.s.
C1	C	class token + conditions + 10 / 3 epochs (CV) (bundle)	cvbase → cvctrl	-0.07	-0.21	-0.28	-0.13	[-0.41, -0.01], better in 5/5 folds	improves
C2	C	T1/T2 dropout + consistency λ 0.1 (CV)	cvctrl → cvaug	-0.03	0.04	0.02	0.07	[-0.16, +0.25], better in 2/5 folds	n.s.
C3	C	median of 5 fold models instead of one (cvctrl)	cvctrl single → cvctrl ensemble	–	-0.18	-0.22	-0.13	[-0.27, -0.09] (bootstrap)	improves
C3b	C	median of 5 fold models instead of one (cvbase)	cvbase single → cvbase ensemble	–	-0.05	-0.06	-0.04	[-0.11, +0.01] (bootstrap)	n.s.

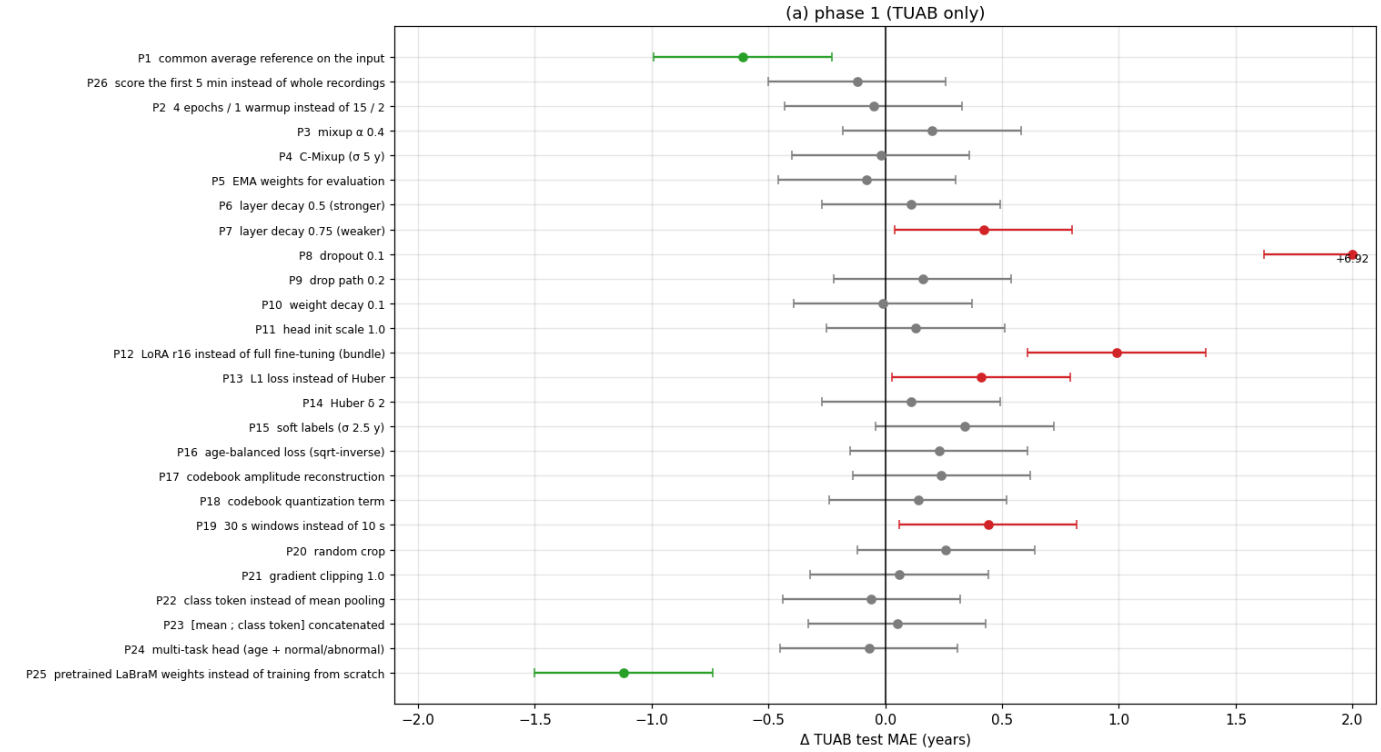
Figure 5.1. Effect sizes

Δ test (Eq. (0.4), TUAB test, all 274 recordings; negative is better) for every row of Table 5.2.

- (a) Phase 1, TUAB-only runs.
- (b) Line removal, phase 2 and CV.

Error bars and colour:

- The bar is the noise band: $\pm\tau$ for single and 3-seed pairs, the 95 % interval for CV and ensemble rows.
- Green = `improves`, red = `hurts`, grey = `n.s.`
- Effects beyond ±2 years (collapsed runs) are drawn at the edge with their value written next to them.



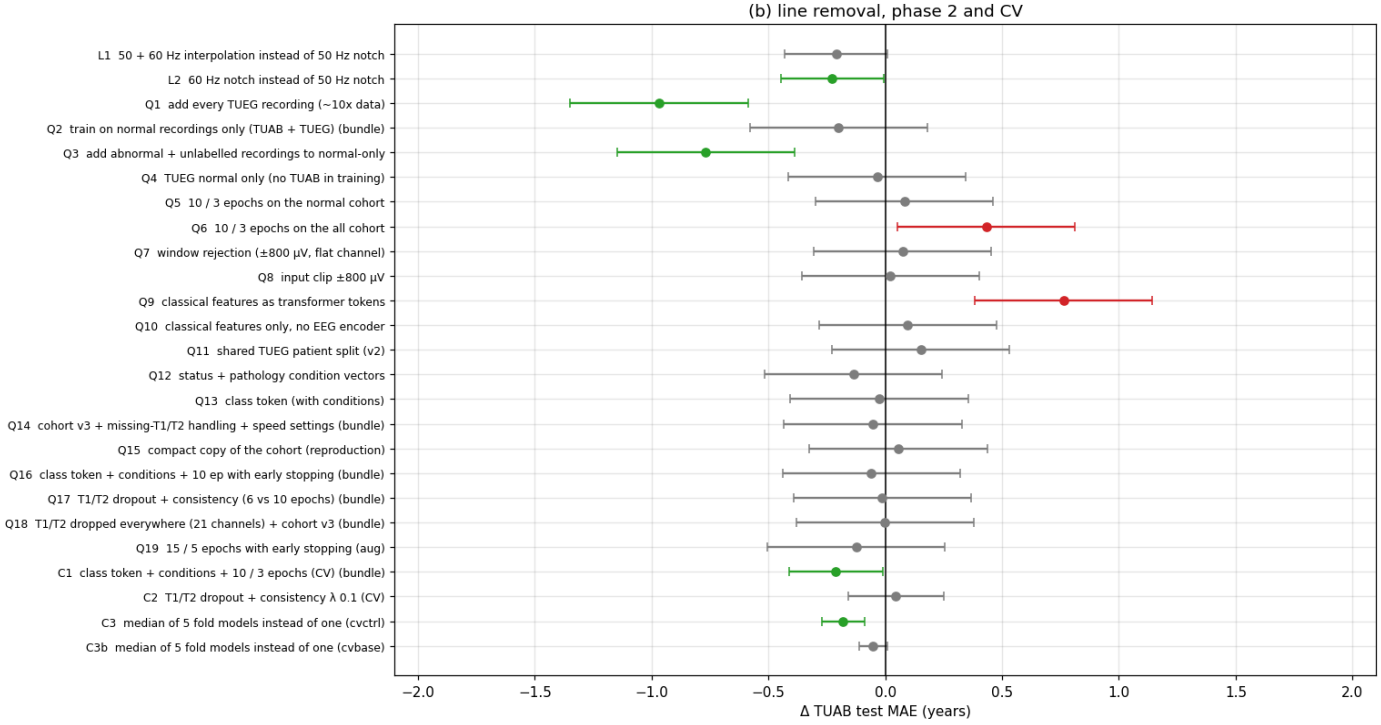


Table 5.3. Changes versus LaBraM: which mattered

The summary the study was after. One row per change from the LaBraM TUAB recipe to the best configuration (Tables 4.1 and 4.2), with:

- `estimate`: the Table 5.2 row that isolates the change best and its Δ test;
- `verdict`: that row's verdict;
- `in best config`: whether the change is part of `cvctrl`.

`not isolated` means no run changes it alone, so its effect is not known.

change vs LaBraM	estimate	Δ test	verdict	in best config
training data: TUAB → TUAB + TUEG (~10x recordings)	Q1: Control → Exp3	-0.97	improves	yes
abnormal and unlabelled recordings in training	Q3: Exp1 → Exp3	-0.77	improves	yes
pretrained LaBraM weights (vs from scratch)	P25: S1 → D	-1.12	improves	yes
common average reference on the input	P1: B → D	-0.61	improves	yes
mains: 50 + 60 Hz interpolation instead of 50 Hz notch	L1: A_notch50 → C_interp5060	-0.21	n.s.	yes
ensemble: median of the 5 fold models	C3: cvctrl single → cvctrl ensemble	-0.18	improves	yes
class token + condition vectors + 10 epochs (bundle)	C1: cvbase → cvctrl	-0.21	improves	yes
condition vectors alone (single split)	Q12: Exp3v2 → Exp3cond	-0.14	n.s.	yes
class-token pooling alone (TUAB / TUH)	P22: D → D-cls	-0.06	n.s.	yes
short schedule (4–10 epochs instead of 15–50)	P2: D → E2	-0.05	n.s.	yes
mixup α 0.4	P3: E2 → M1	0.20	n.s.	yes
cohort v3 + missing-T1/T2 handling + speed settings (bundle)	Q14: Exp3v2 → Exp4base	-0.05	n.s.	yes
5-minute evaluation window	P26: A → B	-0.12	n.s.	yes
T1/T2 channel-dropout augmentation	C2: cvctrl → cvaug	0.04	n.s.	no (cvaug)
longer schedule on the full cohort (10 epochs)	Q6: Exp3 → Exp3b	0.43	hurts	no
dropout 0.1	P8: E2 → F2	6.92	hurts	no
weaker layer decay 0.75	P7: E2 → H1	0.42	hurts	no
LoRA instead of full fine-tuning	P12: E2 → M3	0.99	hurts	no
30 s windows	P19: B → C	0.44	hurts	no
classical features as tokens	Q9: Exp1 → Exp1t	0.76	hurts	no
L1 loss	P13: B → D2	0.41	hurts	no
weight decay, drop path, layer decay 0.5, head init	P10: E2 → F4	-0.01	n.s.	no
loss shape: Huber δ 2, soft labels, age-balanced	P16: E2 → B1	0.23	n.s.	no
codebook regularization	P18: D → DX4	0.14	n.s.	no
signal QC: window rejection / ±800 µV clip	Q7: Exp3 → Exp3q	0.07	n.s.	no
multi-task head	P24: M1 → MT1	-0.07	n.s.	no
trim 60 s at both ends; lr 1e-4 (vs 5e-4); batch 128	–	–	not isolated	yes

6. Conclusions

Generated from the tables above, so they stay in step with the data when the notebook is re-run.

- **Noise floor.** Seed-to-seed sd of the TUAB test MAE is 0.14 years (Table 5.1), so two single runs must differ by more than 0.38 years to count (Eq. (5.2)). Of 51 tested changes, 7 improve, 7 hurt and 37 are within noise (Table 5.2).
- **What improved the error (Table 5.2):** P25 pretrained LaBraM weights instead of training from scratch (-1.12); Q1 add every TUEG recording (~10x data) (-0.97); Q3 add abnormal + unlabelled recordings to normal-only (-0.77); P1 common average reference on the input (-0.61); L2 60 Hz notch instead of 50 Hz notch (-0.23); C1 class token + conditions + 10 / 3 epochs (CV) (bundle) (-0.21); C3 median of 5 fold models instead of one (cvctrl) (-0.18).
- **What hurt:** P13 L1 loss instead of Huber (+0.41); P7 layer decay 0.75 (weaker) (+0.42); Q6 10 / 3 epochs on the all cohort (+0.43); P19 30 s windows instead of 10 s (+0.44); Q9 classical features as transformer tokens (+0.76); P12 LoRA r16 instead of full fine-tuning (bundle) (+0.99); P8 dropout 0.1 (+6.92).
- **Best configuration: `cvctrl`.** TUAB test MAE 7.28 ± 0.14 per fold model (normal 5.53, abnormal 9.37; Table 3.3). Its head is given the status/pathology vector.
- **Best EEG-only: `cvbase`.** 7.49 ± 0.09 per fold model, normal recordings 5.81, against 6.60 for the best published TUAB normal result (Gemein et al. 2024, different split and training data).
- **Ensembles.** The median of the 5 fold models scores 7.10 (`cvctrl`) and 7.44 (`cvbase`) on the TUAB test, normal 5.75 (`cvbase`).
- **Most of the gain over LaBraM comes from data.** The largest effects are:
  - more and more varied training recordings (Q1, Q3);
  - pretrained weights (P25);
  - the common average reference (P1). Architecture, loss and regularization changes are within noise or harmful (Table 5.3).
- **The abnormal cohort carries the error.** Abnormal recordings stay about 4 years worse than normal ones in every configuration (Tables 2.3, 3.3).

Caveats.

- **Selection on test:** phases 1 and 2 chose among configurations on the TUAB test set, so their best single-split numbers are optimistic. The CV and TUEG out-of-fold numbers are not.
- **Bundles:** C1, Q14, Q16, Q17 and Q18 change several things at once, so their parts are not separately known.
- **Condition vectors:** `cvctrl` and `cvaug` use the status/pathology vector at test time. Only `cvbase` is comparable with EEG-only brain-age models.
- **Noise floor scope:** it comes from one configuration family (M1 on TUAB) and is assumed to transfer to the larger cohorts.